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HTC Desire

Highly Desirable

Although the Desire doesn't share the metal construction of the HTC Nexus One, it's a beautiful looking device – slim and sleek. The keys have a matte chrome finish that oozes suave sex appeal. The earpiece consists of twin slits with a chrome trim, and this is, perhaps, the sexiest part of the phone.

Incidentally, the microSD card isn't hot swappable. The power and screen lock button is on the top and is designed to merge with the body. The 3.5mm handsfree jack also sits on the top. On the bottom, a slight protrusion marks the micro USB port for data and charging. Even the rocker-type volume key on the left side fits nearly flush but is very usable.

The Desire's display lives up to the hype. It's huge – 3.7-inches, though not as large as the 4.3-inch display on the Touch HD2. Even better, the Indian market gets a super LCD in lieu of the AMOLED that the Desire was supposed to ship with. Colours are crisp without being over saturated and the display has a great contrast and blackness level. Equally wonderful is the sensitivity of the display – the capacitive technology used is of the highest quality – swipes, gestures, the on-screen keypad – everything works very well.

The Desire features HTC Sense. Although Android has a fairly good menu system, and the Sense UI is not as omnipresent as it was on the HTC Touch HD2, it's still welcome, if not totally necessary. The icons, the interface itself and the beautiful display add to a highly usable experience that is gimmicky yet practical and satisfying.

The browser is lightning fast, supports pinch zooming which is quite useful.

With the Froyo update, the camera records videos up to a resolution of 720p. The videos are clear, although there is blur when moving due to the lack of a proper image stabilisation system. Colours are rich, and in bright light, you won't complain. Indoors the quality drops considerably.

The five-megapixel clicker provides decent clarity for a cell-phone camera, but it's not the best around. The flash unit is very intense, and illuminates a dark room, up to a distance of eight feet pretty well.

HTC endowed the Desire with a loud, but tiny loudspeaker. While at maximum volume it's pretty loud, it distorts a bit. The earphones sound a lot better. Although the bass is lacking and the treble is rolled off, this is pretty much on par with the headsets of most handsets.

Call clarity is good. But the antenna is not. In zone three, we faced disconnected calls on more than one occasion, accompanied by a loss in vocal clarity. In zone two there were sporadic periods of silence, but this wasn't happening with any regularity, that made us suspect a service provider issue. The loudspeaker is loud on-call, but a maximum volume there is jarring and the voice distorts. The earpiece is also pretty loud, but doesn't distort. When using the loudspeaker, the battery cover vibrates.

As desirable as the, err... Desire is, it's not without the odd annoying hiccup. There's the mediocre battery and antenna performance.

The price we got for the Desire was an MOP of ₹28,900. This is the price being offered by Tata Docomo, who is bundling the device with a data plan that offers 500 MB of free data usage every month for the first six months. If only the handful of quirks were ironed out we'd be pleased to live with it. HTC has just announced the Desire HD and the Desire Z, though, and these might be worth looking at. We recommend waiting and watching, unless you have to buy a high-end handset now – in which case the Desire, will make, (most of), yours come true.



OS: Android 2.1; Display: size: 3.7-inch; resolution: 480x800 pixels; CPU: Qualcomm QSD8250 (1 GHz); RAM: 576 MB; ROM: 512 MB; expansion: microSD; Camera: 5-megapixel; battery: 1400 mAh; weight: 135 grams

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Price: ₹28,900

7.5/10

Features.....	8.0
Performance.....	8.0
Build Quality.....	7.0
Value for money.....	7.0

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